INTERPERSONAL FALSE BELIEF #49 · GRIEF AND LOSS

“God took them from me to punish me.”

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Where it often comes from

After a death, guilt over old sins or an unresolved conflict can lead us to wonder if God is repaying us. People of faith can add to this by saying things like “God needed another angel” or “everything happens for a reason,” which can make God sound like the cause of the loss and imply that we deserved it.

What Scripture teaches

Paul writes, “There is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus.” The psalmist says, “He has not dealt with us according to our sins or repaid us according to our iniquities.” When the disciples asked who sinned to cause a man’s suffering, Jesus said that it was not this man or his parents. Jeremiah’s lament says, “Even if He causes grief, He will show compassion.” And “God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us.” Death entered the world through sin and brokenness in general, not as a personal tally against you. God grieves with you.

> *“Even if He causes grief, He will show compassion according to His abundant loving devotion”* (Lamentations 3:32).

Also see

> “Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus” (Romans 8:1).

> “He has not dealt with us according to our sins or repaid us according to our iniquities” (Psalm 103:10).

> “Jesus answered, ‘Neither this man nor his parents sinned, but this happened so that the works of God would be displayed in him.’” (John 9:3).

> “But God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us” (Romans 5:8).

Common self-statements

- I am being punished for my sin.
- God took them because of what I did.
- I deserved to lose them.
- God is angry with me.
- If I had been better, they would be here.
- This is the price of my past.

Common logical errors

- Personalization: Believing the death was about me.
- Magical thinking: Linking my sin to a death.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling guilty and concluding that God punished me.
- Mind reading: Assuming I know God’s motive.

Challenging questions

- What do I believe I did, and have I confessed it?
- Does Scripture teach that God kills loved ones to punish us?

- What did Jesus say when asked whose sin caused suffering?
- What does God's love at the cross say about His attitude toward me?
- Who said that God needed my loved one, and is that biblical?
- What do I need to bring to God in honest prayer?

Truth summary

> God did not take my loved one to punish me. In Christ there is no condemnation, and Jesus rejected the idea that suffering is always payment for sin. God grieves with me, and I can bring my pain and any guilt to Him.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Grief
- Guilt/Shame
- Forgiveness
- Death/Dying
- God, All Loving

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Grief
- Suffering

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Forgiveness — Matthew West
Ask God for help releasing resentment while working through real hurt.

Clean — Natalie Grant
God's cleansing grace challenges the belief that shame or sin makes a person beyond restoration.

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Amazing Grace — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn locates salvation and sustaining hope in grace rather than merit.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

My Plan for Replacing "God took them from me to punish me"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"God took them from me to punish me." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What do I think I am being punished for?
- ☐ Have I confessed?
- ☐ What did Jesus say about suffering?
- ☐ Who told me God needed them?
- ☐ What does the cross show?
- ☐ Who can I talk to?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ There is no condemnation in Christ.
- ☐ God does not repay me according to my sins.
- ☐ Not all suffering is punishment.
- ☐ God shows compassion.
- ☐ God proved His love at the cross.
- ☐ God grieves with me.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Romans 8:1
  "Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus."
- ☐ Lamentations 3:32
  "Even if He causes grief, He will show compassion according to His abundant loving devotion."
- ☐ Psalm 103:10
  "He has not dealt with us according to our sins or repaid us according to our iniquities."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] No punishment: Each time guilt rises, write Romans 8:1 and one truth about God's compassion.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Romans 8:1 becomes: "Sarah can write: "There is no condemnation for me in Christ, so this is not punishment.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Guilt/Shame" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Name the guilt. Write what you think you are being punished for.
- [ ] Confess and receive. Bring any real sin to God and receive forgiveness.
- [ ] Read John 9:1–3. See how Jesus answered the question.
- [ ] Talk with a pastor. Share your fear and ask for biblical perspective.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "God took them from me to punish me": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Condemnation answered
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~God took them from me to punish me.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have wondered if You took them because of me. Thank You that there is no condemnation in Christ. Forgive what needs forgiving, and comfort me with Your compassion. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.